philosophy of a ‘warrior and a winner’, and my motto for our corps, ‘Fight to Win’.

A few days after the exercise, I received a letter of appreciation from the defence minister saying how happy he was with the whole experience. A copy of the letter is reproduced on the next page.

On the culmination of the exercise, no one could have guessed that within a few months, the corps would be headed for the real thing – an actual bout with Pakistan. Terrorism had begun to rear its ugly head all over the world. First came 9/11, which gave a rude shock to America along with the rest of the world, followed by a constitutional crisis in Nepal. Then came the attack on the Indian Parliament by a group of Pakistani terrorists, taking us to the brink of a war. There were other incidents of terrorism – at Akshardham in Gujarat; at the Raghunath temple in Jammu; at the Kalu Chak military station in J&K. Since we had honed our war-fighting skills, we were fully prepared to carry out our assigned mission, and were just awaiting the green signal. Alas, it never came or we could have created history (see also Chapter 20).

We moved into a new sprawling office complex of the Corps HQ at Mathura on returning from the exercise. The corps commander’s office was located on the first floor and had a beautiful view. I was the first GOC to occupy that office. We planned and constructed a small war memorial adjacent to the Corps HQ. In the battle of Basantar in the 1971 Indo-Pak war, Second Lieutenant Arun Khetarpal of 17 Horse was decorated with a Param Vir Chakra and his tank – a Vijayanta – had the pride of place in the memorial. It was one of the best office buildings in those days, and we worked very hard to do up the interiors. During a visit to Mathura in February 2011, I was amazed to see the improvements made over the past decade in the Corps HQ and the cantonment by my distinguished successors.